

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

An innovative urban design

A community college, in a sense, is urban design in miniature—a mini-city with public squares and private retreats, with young people and old, with restaurants, offices, libraries, recreation facilities, parking problems, social problems, but all at a small scale where new solutions can be tested.

As a result, some of the most innovative buildings of the last decade have been in this category. Scarborough College in Toronto, by John Andrews (the architect of Harvard's new design school, Gund Hall) pioneered a spine concept of urban design that had been written about for years, but never built.

Many other recent examples . . . State University of N.Y. College at Purchase, New York, Tougaloo in Mississippi, or most notably the Free University of Berlin—have used the small college design problem as an opportunity to experiment with urban form.

Massachusetts has eight of these colleges, and they run the gamut of possible types. Berkshire College, for example, designed by Ben Thompson, is a loose grouping of small buildings around a kind of New England village common; whereas Holyoke, still under construction by the international firm of Daniel Mann Johnson Mendenhall, is a megastructure, a single building into which all the functions of the college are agglomerated.

Not coincidentally, both village cluster and megastructure have also been fashionable forms in new-town design.

Of the Massachusetts colleges, the biggest and the only one sited in a central city is Bunker Hill College in Charlestown, designed by Jean-Paul Carlhian of the firm of Shepley, Bulfinch, Richardson and Abbott.

Located on a truly appalling site, cut off from everything around it by an overhead expressway, an MBTA line, a four-lane arterial street and the Prison Point Bridge, Bunker Hill

College makes a virtue of necessity by turning itself into a link between the community and the rapid transit station. This connection is effected by a long, raised plaza-walkway which, starting at the transit station (from which most students arrive), passes through the college at the second-floor level and continues as a pedestrian overpass crossing Rutherford Avenue to link up with a new shopping center that will be the focus of the neighborhood.

Where it passes through the college, this raised walkway broadens into a plaza that flows around the auditorium (used for public functions) and past the main entrance to the college. The hope is, that as people go by on their way to the subway, they'll be brought into close contact with the college, which as most community colleges, doubles as a community center.

Opening off this plaza, the college itself is a kind of loose quadrangle of buildings strung together along a second-floor gallery that runs around all four sides of an open courtyard. The gallery connects to everything; distributed along it are many small sitting and lounging areas.

Because of the horrible noise from the expressway overhead and planes from nearby Logan Airport, all the classrooms are buried in the bowels of the building, with no windows, buffered by laboratories above them and faculty offices surrounding them.

Like the classrooms, the whole complex seems to turn inward, away from an environment felt to be threatening, gathering instead around its central courtyard and presenting to the outside world rather bleak and formal facades, a kind of fortress that throws out its overpasses, like drawbridges, as defensible links with the city.

Although the inward-turning quality seems justified in these cir-

cumstances, it's interesting that Bunker Hill shares this quality with two other local projects by the same architect, the Student Union at Northeastern and, to a lesser extent, Mather House at Harvard.

With only a third of the college completed, it's hard, and perhaps unfair, to judge the final effect. Both the architect and the college administration are uncertain about the success of the faculty offices, which aren't offices at all but merely open desks ranged along galleries at half-levels up or down from the classrooms, easily accessible to students, in an arrangement that resembles the officers' stations on a typical banking floor.

The buildings as a whole have a rather bland and formal quality, with little color and much symmetry. This may change when they fill with student life, and when the landscape, now terribly bare, is filled with the trees it desperately needs.

For years, it seemed that Boston's planners had consigned Charlestown to the role of a huge traffic interchange. Although they almost succeeded, the tide seems to be turning.

With its many streets of fine brick and wood townhouses, many now being restored by the middle classes who appear to be fleeing back from the suburbs, with a supply of new moderate-income housing, with the fine new Kent School, and with the opportunity that is presented by the naval shipyard site, Charlestown appears to have survived the onslaught of the highways with much of its charm and diversity intact.

One may hope that Bunker Hill College, symbolically spanning highways to lead pedestrians to a mass transit station, marks the end of the planning crimes of the automobile age and the beginning of a renaissance for Charlestown.